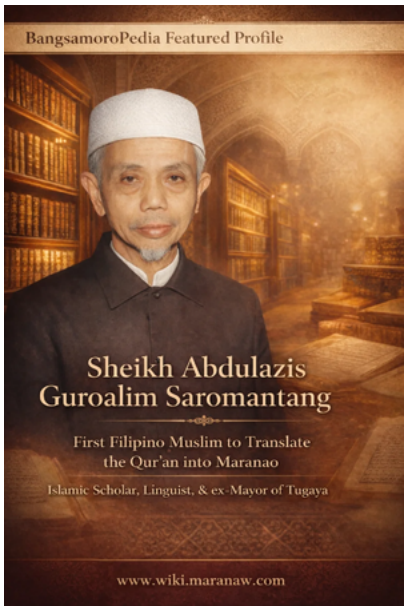
# Abdulazis Guroalim Saromantang

**Sheikh Abdulazis Guroalim Saromantang** (Rahimahullah) (also spelled *Abdulaziz Guroalim Saromantang* was a pioneering Maranao Islamic scholar and the first Filipino Muslim to complete a full translation of the Qur'an into the Maranao language. A native of Tugaya, Lanao del Sur, he bridged the spiritual and political spheres, serving as the municipality's mayor while simultaneously undertaking one of the most significant religious scholarship projects in Philippine Islamic history. His vernacular Qur'an translation, published by the King Fahd Complex in Madinah, remains the definitive reference for over 1.3 million Maranao-speaking Muslims across Mindanao and the diaspora.

## Contents


1 Early Life and Heritage
2 Political and Civic Leadership
3 Path to the Qur'an Translation
4 The Translation Project
5 Publication and Title
6 Legacy and Cultural Impact
7 Orthographic Innovation
8 Scholarly Reception and Debate
    8.1 Critical Perspectives
    8.2 Scholarly Defenses
9 Death and Ongoing Legacy
10 See Also
11 Further Reading


**Sheikh Abdulazis Guroalim Saromantang**




| | |
|---|---|
| Born | Unknown (early 20th century) |
| Died | Unknown (date not specified in sources) |
| Ethnicity | Maranao |
| Religion | Islam |
| Birthplace | Tugaya, Lanao del Sur, Mindanao, Philippines |
| Notable Works | *So Qur'an al Karim ago so Kiya pema ana iron Ko basa a iranon sa pilimpinas* (First Complete Maranao Qur'an Translation) |
| Political Office | Ex-Mayor of Tugaya |
| Academic Role | Ulama, Religious Scholar, Qur'an Translator |
| Organizational Affiliation | King Fahd Complex for the Printing of the Holy Qur'an |

## Early Life and Heritage

Abdulazis Guroalim Saromantang was born into the Maranao community of Tugaya, a municipality in Lanao del Sur long regarded as a center of Islamic scholarship in Mindanao. The Maranao, often described as "the people of the lake" for their historical settlement around Lake Lanao, had developed a sophisticated oral tradition of Islamic learning passed through successive generations of Ulama.

Saromantang emerged from this cultural foundation as a "home-grown" scholar, initially teaching in local madrasas (Islamic schools) before gaining recognition for his exceptional mastery of classical Arabic and Islamic jurisprudence. Unlike many of his contemporaries who sought advanced training exclusively in the Middle East, Saromantang's early education was rooted in the Maranao scholarly tradition, where he developed an intimate understanding of both Arabic linguistic nuances and the vernacular idioms of his people.

His family later became one of Tugaya's most prominent households, producing subsequent generations of Islamic leaders and cultural advocates. His grandsons would later become vocal defenders of his scholarly legacy during academic and theological debates.

## Political and Civic Leadership

Before devoting himself fully to the monumental task of Qur'an translation, Saromantang served as Mayor of Tugaya during the 1960s. This period in his life reflected a distinctive Maranao leadership model where religious scholarship and civic governance were not seen as competing pursuits but as complementary responsibilities to the community.

As mayor, he navigated the complex political landscape of post-independence Mindanao while maintaining his reputation as a principled Islamic scholar. This dual role demonstrated his ability to operate effectively in both traditional and modern institutional frameworks, a capacity that would later prove invaluable when engaging with Saudi Arabian government officials and the international Islamic academic community.

## Path to the Qur'an Translation

The idea of translating the Qur'an into Maranao did not originate with Saromantang alone. In the 1980s, the Saudi Arabian government, through the King Fahd Complex for the Printing of the Holy Qur'an, launched an initiative to support vernacular translations of the Qur'an in minority Muslim communities worldwide. Saromantang was identified and officially commissioned as the first, and ultimately the only, Filipino Muslim scholar authorized to undertake this task.

The decision to entrust this responsibility to Saromantang was not arbitrary. His reputation for linguistic precision, theological grounding, and deep knowledge of Maranao cultural idioms made him the obvious choice. Unlike a direct, word-for-word rendering, the translation required solving a unique challenge: how to convey the theological depth and poetic beauty of classical Arabic within the grammatical and phonological constraints of Maranao, a language that had never before been systematically used for complex religious discourse.

## The Translation Project

What began in the early 1980s as an ambitious vision became a painstaking, methodical labor that would define Saromantang's final decades. The project consumed 10 years of intense, focused translation work. During this period, Saromantang did not work in isolation. He led a collaborative panel of respected Islamic and cultural figures, including the late Senator Ahmad Domocao Alonto (a prominent Maranao political figure and Islamic scholar) and Imam Nashrodeen Basman, to ensure the translation's theological accuracy and cultural appropriateness.

The completed manuscript then entered a rigorous validation phase. For an additional 5 years, a committee of Maranao Shariah scholars at the Islamic University of Madinah scrutinized every verse, cross-referencing Saromantang's Maranao renderings against the original Arabic text and established interpretive traditions. This dual-phase process, spanning 15 years total, meant that the translation was not merely a one-person achievement but a validated scholarly work blessed by one of Islam's most prestigious academic institutions.

# Publication and Title

The translation was finally published in the 1990s by the King Fahd Complex in Madinah, with a standard edition running approximately 1,088 pages. The full title in Maranao was *So Qur'an al Karim ago so Kiya pema ana iron Ko basa a iranon sa pilimpinas*, which translates roughly as "The Noble Qur'an and Its Meaning in the Maranao Language in the Philippines."

The publication marked a historic milestone. Notably, Saromantang's Maranao translation was completed before the Tagalog translation of the Qur'an was finished, meaning that Maranao speakers gained access to their own vernacular Qur'an before the larger Filipino Christian and Muslim populations received a comparable Tagalog edition.

The standard edition was assigned ISBN 9960-847-34-9. Subsequent printings and digital editions followed, including a widely cited 1422 AH edition (approximately 2001-2002) from the King Fahd National Library catalog.

# Legacy and Cultural Impact

Saromantang's translation achieved something more significant than a simple linguistic conversion. It affirmed that the Maranao language, long marginalized in academic and religious contexts, was capable of expressing the full theological complexity of Islamic revelation. This shift had profound implications for Maranao cultural identity.

The translation proved immediately valuable to Maranao Muslim communities. By making the Qur'an accessible in the vernacular language spoken at home, in markets, and in mosques, Saromantang's work deepened the spiritual engagement of ordinary believers who might struggle with Classical Arabic or reliance on Malay as an auxiliary religious language.

His work has since been integrated into multiple modern formats. Maranao Muslims now access his translation through dedicated mobile applications, including the *Quran Maranao MP3 Translation* app (updated around 2023), and through YouTube playlists featuring his audio recitations. These digital distributions have extended the reach of his work globally, allowing diaspora communities and new generations to encounter the Qur'an in their ancestral language.

Academic archives, including the University of Hawaii and the Maisie van Vactor Collection at Brigham Young University, now catalog his work as a significant contribution to Maranao linguistic and religious scholarship.

# Orthographic Innovation

Beyond the translation itself, Saromantang made an enduring contribution to Maranao orthography. Working alongside Ahmad Domocao Alonto and Aleem Abdulmajeed Ansano, he developed a standardized writing system for Maranao that departed from earlier romanized conventions influenced by Filipino standards.

The most distinctive feature of his orthographic system is its explicit marking of "heavy" or aspirated consonants, sounds that are phonologically contrastive in Maranao but are typically ignored in simplified modern scripts. Where common standardized systems would write "p," "t," "k," and "s," Saromantang's system distinguishes these from their aspirated counterparts through digraphs: "ph," "th," "kh," and "z" (or "sh").

For example:

- *phaphaag* versus *papaag* (heavy p versus plain p)

- *thatharo* versus *tataro* (heavy t versus plain t)
- *khipananangggila* versus *kipananangggila* (heavy k versus plain k)

This system reflects sophisticated phonological knowledge. Saromantang recognized that vowels undergo predictable changes after heavy consonants, and his orthography accounts for this variation by allowing the heavy consonant marker itself to signal the correct pronunciation without requiring additional diacritics.

His handling of vowels and the mid-central schwa (the neutral vowel sound) also reflected careful linguistic observation. Where modern dictionaries might use complex digraphs, Saromantang's system keeps vowel letters simple and lets the preceding heavy consonant context guide pronunciation.

Academic linguists have recognized this system for its phonological accuracy, particularly in representing Maranao sounds that earlier Western linguistic studies had overlooked. While modern educational standards increasingly align with national Komisyon sa Wikang Filipino recommendations (which favor spellings like "Maranaw" and "tabangay" over his "Maranao" and "tabangai"), specialists in Maranao language acknowledge Saromantang's system as uniquely suited for precise native recitation and preservation of linguistic subtleties.

# Scholarly Reception and Debate

Saromantang's translation did not escape academic scrutiny. The process of rendering Classical Arabic into any vernacular language inevitably involves interpretive choices, and his work became the subject of significant scholarly debate within Islamic and linguistic circles.

## Critical Perspectives

The most notable critiques emerged from scholars outside the Maranao community, particularly from Maguindanaon Islamic figures like Ustaz Mohammad Sulaiman. Their arguments centered on three main points:

- **Literalism and Theological Interpretation:** Critics argued that Saromantang's approach to certain passages leaned too heavily toward literal word-for-word correspondence, potentially resulting in theological meanings that, while etymologically accurate to the Arabic roots, diverged from established Islamic exegetical traditions.

- **The "Cow" Controversy:** A specific and widely discussed critique focused on a verse in *Surah Al-Baqarah* (the second chapter of the Qur'an). Critics claimed that a literal rendering of certain divine attributes in Maranao inadvertently used language associated with an animal, which they deemed a serious error in Islamic exegesis and potentially offensive to believers. This critique, though specific, reflected broader concerns about the challenges of conveying divine imagery across linguistic and cultural boundaries.

- **Dialectal Bias:** Some observers noted that Saromantang's translation incorporated linguistic nuances so deeply rooted in the Tugaya dialect of Maranao that scholars and speakers from other Maranao regions (or from neighboring ethnolinguistic groups like the Maguindanaon) sometimes found the text difficult to reconcile with their own regional pronunciation and theological understanding.

## Scholarly Defenses

In response, Maranao scholars and Saromantang's family have mounted several compelling defenses grounded in institutional validation and linguistic science:

- **Rigorous Review Process:** Defenders, including his grandsons Rasol Abbas and Rashid Gurualim, stressed that the translation underwent a full 5-year expert review by a committee of Maranao Shariah scholars at the

Islamic University of Madinah before being cleared for publication by the King Fahd Complex. This institutional endorsement from one of the Islamic world's most respected academic centers carries significant weight.

- **Orthographic Precision:** Saromantang is recognized in academic literature for developing the first writing system capable of accurately representing the full phonological inventory of Maranao, including sounds that had been overlooked by previous Western linguists. This precision, while sometimes creating a translation that feels demanding to modern readers, reflects scholarly rigor.

- **Vernacular Empowerment:** Studies on interlinear religious translations in Mindanao credit Saromantang with shifting the region away from dependence on Malay as the default auxiliary language for complex Islamic thought. His work established Maranao as a legitimate, sophisticated vehicle for theological discourse, a contribution that transcends the translation itself.

# Death and Ongoing Legacy

The exact date of Saromantang's death is not specified in available sources, though he is referred to in respectful terms as "Rahimahullah" (may God have mercy upon him), a phrase used to honor deceased Muslims of standing in the community.

What is certain is that his work continues to shape the spiritual lives of Maranao Muslims. Each time a believer opens the Qur'an in their mother tongue and encounters Saromantang's carefully chosen words, they encounter not merely a translation but a bridge between the sacred text and their own cultural identity.

His family, particularly his descendants, have become stewards of his legacy, defending his scholarly choices and ensuring that his translation remains accessible to new generations through modern digital platforms. The ongoing updates to Maranao Qur'an mobile applications and audio recordings represent an extension of his original vision: making the word of God available in the language of the Maranao people.

# See Also

- Maranao language
- Qur'an translations
- Ahmad Domocao Alonto (collaborator on the translation project)
- Islamic University of Madinah
- King Fahd Complex for the Printing of the Holy Qur'an
- Bangsamoro Islamic scholarship
- Tugaya, Lanao del Sur

# Further Reading


- Alonto, Ahmad Domocao. *Islamic Law Among the Maranao Muslims of the Philippines*. University of the Philippines Press, 1987.
- Ansano, Aleem Abdulmajeed. *Studies in Maranao Orthography and Linguistic Development*. Islamic University of Madinah Press, 2005.
- van Vactor, Maisie. *Maranao Language and Literature: A Comprehensive Bibliography*. Brigham Young University, 1995.

**Editorial Notice:** BangsamoroPedia is a curated knowledge archive. Its pages are maintained by the editorial administrator to help ensure historical accuracy. If you would like to suggest corrections, share sources, or contribute information, please message the administrator through the official Facebook page: **Notable Muslim Filipinos**.

Retrieved from "https://wiki.maranaw.com/index.php?title=Abdulazis_Guroalim_Saromantang&oldid=1667"